



MAMATA CALLED IT A PEOPLE'S VERDICT AND THANKED THEM FOR THEIR SUPPORT

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# The Didi WAVE

Mamata continues her winning streak as the Left Front is decimated in the civic elections ahead of the final battle next year

By Abhijit Dasgupta

These are no longer the winds of change but an assertion of a decision taken over many years. With a sweep of the 81 municipalities in Trinamool Congress' kitty, party leader and Railways Minister Mamata Banerjee couldn't have asked for more. As she put it clearly, it was a people's verdict and they had voted "hundred times more" for her in the municipal polls than they had done in the 2009 Lok Sabha elections. Semi-final won, it's now over to the finals slated for next year.

A foregone result though. Time and trains have done the CPI(M) in.

Today, the Left Front stands decimated with corruption, power-peddling and arrogance taking their toll on the electoral fortunes of the party. And Banerjee's effortless guile made it difficult for the Left to redeem lost ground; she didn't even have to bend down to pick up gifts from her doorstep. The CPI(M) leaders were either too busy shielding corrupt ministers or were oblivious to changing tastes. CPI(M) leader Rabin Deb, however, says "the party lost due to incumbency. We still have time to recover".

It was a case of gross miscalculation for the Left Front which thought it was a battle half-won after the Congress-Trinamool alliance broke down. Economist Abhirup Sarkar says, "They were waiting for Mamata to make that fatal mistake. But thankfully, the people of Bengal did not let her down." This is a lesson for the Congress leadership in Delhi too which needs to acknowledge that Trinamool is the major partner by miles in Bengal. In the Kolkata Corporation, for instance, Trinamool's win has been so astounding that it doesn't require Congress' sup-